



Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment Reform - CoARA Action Plan

Tuscan Organisation of Universities and Research for Europe (TOUR4EU)

Presentation of TOUR4EU

TOUR4EU (Tuscan Organisation of Universities and Research for Europe) is a non-profit association under Belgian law which brings together the Tuscany Region and its seven universities (University of Florence, University of Pisa, University of Siena, University for Foreigners of Siena, IMT School for Advanced Studies Lucca, Scuola Normale Superiore and Scuola Superiore Sant'Anna) to promote the interests of the Tuscan research system at the EU level and to strengthen its internationalisation.

The Association is responsible for engaging with European Union institutions and other strategic stakeholders to identify and secure opportunities and funding and to promote synergies, internationalisation and scientific cooperation.

TOUR4EU represents in Brussels a university system of excellence, the Tuscan one, composed of more than 8.640 teachers, researchers and doctoral students, 122.898 students, which generates to date 163 university spin-offs and 404 laboratories.

TOUR4EU involvement in the Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment

The Association has actively joined the Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment since the beginning of the process, in January 2022. In the following months, the Universities of TOUR4EU that signed the CoARA Agreement are the following: University of Florence, University of Pisa, University for Foreigners of Siena, Scuola Normale Superiore, Scuola Superiore Sant'Anna and IMT School for Advanced Studies Lucca.

As research is rapidly evolving, outputs are no longer limited to only publications, but involve a broader set of results. For this reason, The Association calls for enhancing the diversity of research outputs and practices, which are crucial elements on which the existence of scientific research relies. This includes advocating for open science practices that contribute to research efficiency and quality.

At the end of February 2023, TOUR4EU and CNR co-organised an open event in collaboration with the Informal Network representing the Italian Research and Innovation community in Brussels (GIURI) with the aim of discussing the framework for the reform of the research evaluation system.



The objective of the event was twofold: first, to trace the main factors that led to the creation of CoARA, second, to foster the debate among Italian stakeholders on the potential impact of this initiative in Italy. TOUR4EU actively participated by engaging in a dialogue with representatives from the Tuscan Universities involved in the research and evaluation fields, fostering a collaborative discussion on the CoARA initiative's importance and implications for the Italian and Tuscan research ecosystems.

Since the launch of the call by the Coalition, TOUR4EU and the Tuscan Universities have expressed interest in taking part in **CoARA's working groups** and are currently part of the following ones:

- *Multilingualism and language biases in research assessment* (**TOUR4EU**, University for Foreigners of Siena and University of Pisa);
- *Experiments in Assessment - Idea generation, co-creation, and piloting* (IMT School for Advanced Studies Lucca);
- *Responsible metrics and indicators* (University of Pisa and IMT School for Advanced Studies Lucca);
- *Improving practices in the assessment of research proposals* (University of Pisa and University of Florence);
- *Towards transformations: transdisciplinary, applied/practice-based research and impact* (University of Florence);
- *TIER-Towards an inclusive evaluation of research* (University of Florence, Scuola Normale Superiore and University for Foreigners of Siena);
- *Global framework for research evaluation in the social sciences and humanities* (University for Foreigners of Siena).

Finally, TOUR4EU and the Tuscan Universities actively participate in the Italian "National Chapter" chaired by the University of Bologna and the CNR.

TOUR4EU role in the Coalition: focus and priorities

As TOUR4EU is an organisation that is not directly and concretely involved in research and evaluation processes, its role in the Coalition will consist mainly in facilitating exchange of knowledge and monitoring activities to support its Universities in the implementation of their CoARA action plans and in the working groups active participation.

In order to reach this objective, TOUR4EU commits itself to the following actions:

- I) Facilitate on a regular basis the flow of information from the COARA secretariat to the universities in order to promote participation in the initiatives, exchange of good practices and cascading calls launched by the coalition.
Timeframe: from 2024.
- II) Organise at least once per year a meeting with Tuscan Universities and the Research and Higher Education Department of the Tuscany Region on the progress of the Universities Action plans' implementation to ensure coherence with the regional ecosystem policies and to inform on the National Chapter and the working groups activities within the COARA Coalition.
Timeframe: from 2024.
- III) Support Tuscan Universities in the realisation of seminars and events within their action plans to raise awareness of Open Science practices and COARA principles within the academic community, ensuring that everyone is informed and engaged.
Timeframe: from 2024.
- IV) Contribute to organise a seminar per year within the Informal Network representing the Italian Research and Innovation community in Brussels (GIURI) in accordance with the Italian National Chapter chairs with the objective to monitor and foster the exchange of information with the other Italian Organisations involved in the CoARA and promote the initiative with institutions not yet involved.
Timeframe: from 2025.
- V) Participate to events and contribute to the realisation of the Action Plan within the *Multilingualism and language biases in research assessment* working group, in particular chairing the sub-group *Language learning and skills* in partnership with University for Foreigners of Siena and University of Pisa already present in the group.
Timeframe: from 2024.
- VI) Contribute to the National Chapter under University of Bologna and CNR coordination and update on *Multilingualism and language biases in research assessment* working group activities.
Timeframe: from 2024



- VII) Devote in TOUR4EU website a session on COARA and Tuscan universities activities including action plans addressed to researchers in order to strengthen transparent communication and understanding. Promote articles and activities in the TOUR4EU social media.

Timeframe: from mid - 2024